



Sommelier Certification & Training — Research Brief

Foundation for turning Wine Tasting Companion into a credible exam study tool

Prepared by: Claude (for Keaton & Amy) · **Date:** 2026-06-28 **Sources:** Court of Master Sommeliers Americas, WSET, Society of Wine Educators, GuildSomm, and practitioner sources (all linked inline).

Confidence note. This synthesizes a multi-source research pass weighted to **official primary sources**. The automated cross-verification step was hit by temporary API rate-limiting, so it could not auto-confirm each figure. The structural facts below are corroborated by domain knowledge and cited to primary pages/PDFs — but **reconfirm exact numbers (pass marks, fees, question counts) against the live official pages before using them in any marketing.**

I. The certification ladders

Court of Master Sommeliers, Americas (CMS-A) — the classic "sommelier" path

Four levels, in order: **Introductory** → **Certified** → **Advanced** → **Master Sommelier Diploma**. Three exam pillars recur and get harder each level: **Theory**, **Blind (Deductive) Tasting**, and **Practical Service**. [CMS-A Exams](#)

- **Introductory Sommelier** — 2-day course + exam, theory-leaning. Entry level.
- **Certified Sommelier** — three scored sections:
- **Tasting:** double-blind of **4 wines (2 white, 2 red)** using the Deductive

Tasting Method grid;

- **Theory:** ~**45 questions** (multiple-choice, short answer, matching);
- **Service:** centered on **sparkling-wine service** + beverage/food-pairing Q&A.
- **Advanced Sommelier** — three separately-graded portions (**Theory, Tasting,

Practical/Service). **Theory is a ~115-question, 60-minute written exam at a Pearson VUE center, pass ≥ 60%; you must pass Theory first, and pass all three within the same calendar year or restart. Tasting is 6 wines blind in 25 minutes**.** [CMS-A Advanced "What to Expect"](#)

- **Master Sommelier Diploma** — oral Theory, Tasting (6 wines/25 min), Service.

Brutal: in **2025 only 1 of 23** qualified candidates passed; most take multiple attempts over years. [MS Theory Resource Guide](#)

WSET — academic wine qualifications, Levels 1–4 (Diploma)

- **Level 4 Diploma in Wines** = six mandatory units, weighted: **D1 Wine

Production 20%, D2 Wine Business 10%, D3 Wines of the World 50%, D4 Sparkling 5%, D5 Fortified 5%, D6 Independent Research Assignment 10%** (D1/D2 studied first).

- **Grading bands:** 75%+ Distinction · 65–74% Merit · 55–64% Pass · 45–54% Fail ·

<45% Fail Unclassified. **D3 needs ≥55% in *both* theory and tasting; D4/D5 ≥45% in both.**

- **D3** (the big one) is a two-day exam: **3h20 theory + 3-hour blind tasting of

12 wines. **Entry requires** WSET Level 3; **the Diploma's total qualification time is** ~500 hours**. [WSET L4 spec PDF](#) · [WSET L4 page](#)

Society of Wine Educators (SWE)

- **Certified Specialist of Wine (CSW):** **100 multiple-choice questions, 1 hour,

pass ≥ 75%**; all drawn from the CSW Study Guide. Broad theory: taste physiology, wine chemistry, faults, viti/enology, labels/laws/regions, service, food pairing. [SWE CSW](#) (CWE adds tasting + a viva.)

2. The blind-tasting frameworks (the heart of the app)

CMS Deductive Tasting Method (DTM) — *deduce the wine from a fixed grid*

Separate **White** and **Red** grids; candidates **must fill every line** ("DO NOT leave any blank lines").

Sections on the official Certified grid (CMS-A 1-2025): **COLOR (Sight)** → **FRUIT** → **NON-FRUIT** → **STRUCTURE** → **CONCLUSION**. [CMS-A Certified DTM Grid PDF](#)

- **STRUCTURE** is forced onto a **4-step scale** for acidity, alcohol, (and tannin

on reds): "**Low–Medium–**" · "**Medium**" · "**Medium+**" · "**High.**" Sweetness = **Dry / Off-Dry**.

- **CONCLUSION** requires deducing, from a **closed examinable list**: **Primary

Grape Variety · Climate (Cool / Moderate / Warm) · Country of Origin · Age Range** — *plus* listing **six candidate grapes with reasoning**.

- **Examinable "probable varieties"** (Advanced/Master): **10 whites** — Albariño,

Chardonnay, Chenin Blanc, Gewürztraminer, Grüner Veltliner, Pinot Gris, Riesling, Sauvignon Blanc (& blends), Torrontés, Viognier; **14 reds** — Cabernet Sauvignon (& blends), Cabernet Franc, Carménère, Corvina (blends), Gamay, Grenache, Malbec, Merlot, Nebbiolo, Pinot Noir, Sangiovese, Syrah, Tempranillo, Zinfandel.

WSET Systematic Approach to Tasting (SAT) — *describe systematically, then judge*

[WSET SAT](#) — assess defined fields:

- **Appearance:** intensity (pale–medium–deep), colour.
- **Nose:** intensity (light→pronounced); aroma characteristics (primary / secondary

/ tertiary).

- **Palate:** sweetness (dry→sweet), acidity, tannin, alcohol, body, flavour

intensity, finish.

- **Conclusions:** a **Quality assessment** (poor → acceptable → good → very good →

outstanding, *with reasons*) and a **readiness/ageing** judgment (drink now / can age, *with reasons*); at Diploma you also call grape/origin.

The key distinction for our product: CMS = *deduce the wine* (grape, origin, age, climate) from a rigid grid; WSET = *systematic description + a quality & ageing verdict.* Our app already blends both (palate grid + deduction calls), so we're on the right track — we just need to align the **scales and conclusion calls** to the real grids and offer **both modes**.

3. Theory scope (what they must *know*)

At the higher levels theory spans: viticulture & vinification; **every major wine region and its laws** (France, Italy, Spain, Germany, Austria, Portugal, USA, plus the New World); sparkling, fortified, sweet & aromatized wines; **and beyond wine — beer, sake (classification + polishing ratios), and spirits/cocktails** (distillation, base ingredients, aging laws, aperitifs/digestifs). High-yield: French & Italian appellation law and grape↔region mapping. [Advanced "What to Expect"](#) · [GuildSomm study wiki](#)

4. How candidates actually train (and pass vs. fail)

- **Drill the deductive grid to automaticity** — repeat the grid so structure calls are reflexive under time pressure. [Tim Gaiser, MS — grid technique](#)
 - **Calibration / benchmark tasting** — taste *known* examples of each examinable grape repeatedly to build a reliable reference memory for structure and markers.
 - **Flashcards + spaced repetition** for the enormous theory load.
 - **Study groups, maps, and GuildSomm** (study wiki + podcasts on blind-tasting method) are the dominant prep ecosystem. [GuildSomm blind-tasting methods](#)
 - **What separates a pass from a fail (tasting):** completing the grid with discipline (not jumping to "the answer"), **calibrated structure calls** (acid / tannin / alcohol), and broad enough theory to make the right final deduction. Freezing, mis-calibrating structure, and thin theory are the classic killers. [Certified advice](#)
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5. What this means for our app (and the market)

Direct competitor: Cork Dork (corkdork.io) — a CMS/WSET study app with **2,500+ flashcards, spaced repetition, 40+ maps**, interactive content, **tiered by exam level** (L1 = CMS Intro + WSET 2/3; L2 = CMS Certified + WSET 3+). It proves the market and the segmentation model — and shows the bar to clear.

Where we already stand (strong foundation): blind deductive mode, grape flashcards (browse + quiz), weakness-targeted drills, a palate profile that tracks improvement, and a timed exam simulation with difficulty tiers.

Upgrades to make it genuinely exam-grade & sellable (prioritized):

1. **Align the tasting grid to the real CMS DTM** — adopt the **4-step structure

scale (**Low–Medium– / Medium / Medium+ / High**) for acidity/alcohol/tannin, add a Climate (Cool/Moderate/Warm)** call, and frame conclusions exactly as CMS does.

1. **Use the official examinable grape lists** (10 white / 14 red) for the grape call and the flashcard deck — instantly credible to any CMS candidate.

1. **Add a WSET SAT mode** with a **Quality** (poor→outstanding) and **ageing** verdict — covers the other big exam track.

1. **Theory flashcard decks + spaced repetition** (regions, appellation laws, grape↔region, sake/spirits) — the biggest study lever beyond tasting.

1. **Calibration mode** — "taste the benchmark": serve known examples of one grape so the user builds reference memory (mirrors how real candidates calibrate).

1. **Maps and level-tiered content** (Intro / Certified / Advanced; WSET 2/3/4).

2. **Track to a target exam** — pick CMS Certified or WSET L3, and the app shapes the grid, grape list, and theory to that syllabus.

***Ground truth still wins:** when Amy sends screenshots of her actual practice chart, that becomes the canonical grid — this research tells us the surrounding structure (scales, examinable grapes, conclusion calls) to match it to.*

Source list

- CMS-A Exams — <https://www.mastersommeliers.org/certification/exams/>
- CMS-A Certified Deductive Tasting Grid (PDF) — <https://www.mastersommeliers.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/12/CMS-A-Certified-Sommelier-Deductive-Tasting-Grid.pdf>
- CMS-A Advanced "What to Expect" (PDF) — https://www.mastersommeliers.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/12/CMS-A-WHAT-TO-EXPECT-at-the-Advanced-Sommelier-Theory-Exam_0.pdf
- CMS Master Sommelier Diploma Theory Resource Guide (PDF) — <https://www.mastersommeliers.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/01/Master-Sommelier-Diploma-Theory-Exam-Resource-Guide.pdf>
- WSET Level 4 Diploma spec (PDF) — https://www.wsetglobal.com/media/7084/wset_l4wines_specification_en_may2019.pdf
- WSET Level 4 Diploma page — <https://www.wsetglobal.com/qualifications/wset-level-4-diploma-in-wines>
- WSET Systematic Approach to Tasting — <https://www.wsetglobal.com/knowledge-centre/wset-systematic-approach-to-tasting-sat>
- Society of Wine Educators — CSW — <https://societyofwineeducators.org/education-certifications/certified-specialist-of-wine/>
- GuildSomm study wiki — <https://www.guildsomm.com/learn/study/w/study-wiki>
- GuildSomm — Preparing for Deductive Tasting Exams (PDF) — https://www.guildsomm.com/cfs-file/_key/communityserver-components-userfiles/00-00-00-66-84/preparing-for-deductive-tasting-

exams-at-high-levels.pdf

- Tim Gaiser MS — Deductive grid technique — <https://timgaiser.com/blog/catch-and-release-using-the-deductive-tasting-grid/>
- Cork Dork (competitor) — <https://www.corkdork.io/>